

1920–1929

AT THE BEACH

For centuries respectable women had feared the effects of the sun, but now that fashionable clothing exposed more skin, men and women entered the “suntan era”. If the real thing was elusive, sunshine lamps, suntan stockings, and suntan powder could be used to achieve the desired complexion. Alabaster skin once denoted a life free of outdoor work; now it signified an indoor life of office or factory drudgery. From 1922 wealthy sun-seekers and those wanting to try their luck in one of the Grand Casinos could board the luxurious Blue Train in Calais at 1pm and arrive on the Côte d’Azur the next morning. These novel pursuits provided opportunities for sartorial invention – revealing bathing suits cried out for a practical cover. The “divine sloppiness” of beach or Lido pyjamas became so irresistible that in 1933 the Riviera resort of Juan-les-Pins was christened “Pyjamapolis”, a tag that equally could have been applied to Malibu or Palm Beach.

PARASOLS

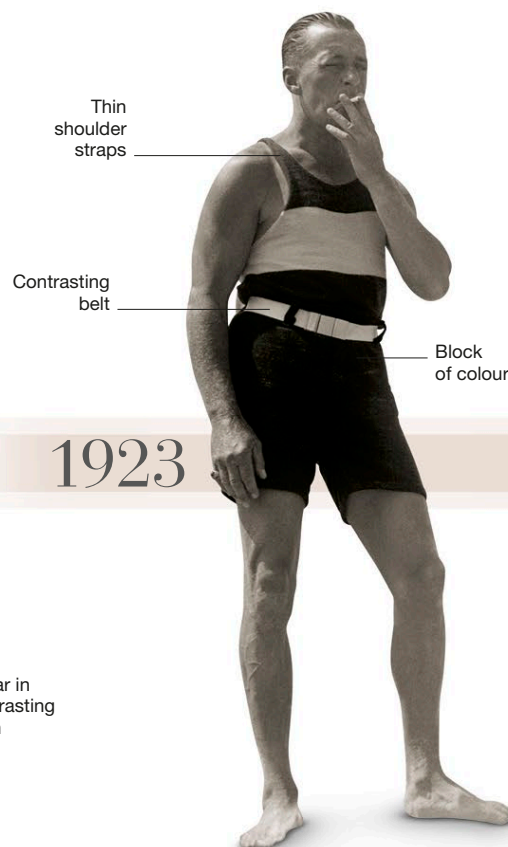
While at the beach, parasols provided shelter from the sun and wind, as well as being stylish accessories.

At this time bold printed fabrics were often chosen, in silk or its newly popular synthetic alternative, rayon. Oriental parasols, that were made from varnished paper and decorated with exotic designs, were also fashionable at seaside resorts across Europe.



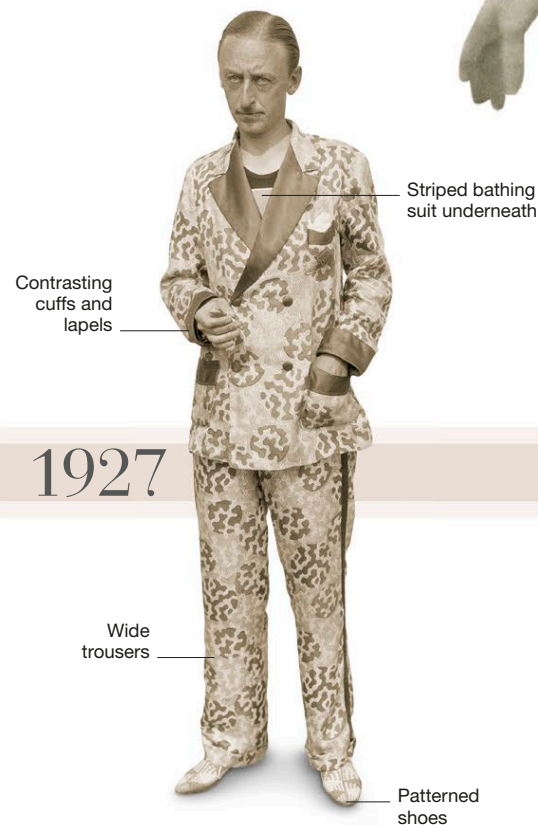
1926

Lido wear The sandy beach of the Venetian Lido island gave its name to seaside resorts and pools, as well as fashionable beach wear. These pyjamas of royal blue georgette feature a collar, tie, and facings of contrasting jade satin.



1923

Cool bathing The wealthy stockbroker E.F. Hutton, owner of the largest private sea-going yacht of the era, shows off his tanned physique in the typical, fashionably striped and belted one-piece male bathing suit of the 1920s.



1927

Palm Beach The riotously patterned beach pyjamas of Mr Kenneth B. Van Riper of New York are a far cry from formal wear, but they do feature adorned side seams also found on tuxedo or dinner suit trousers.